

Suicide

Suicide is death caused by self-harm with the goal of dying. Suicide may seem like the only solution in your current situation, but help is available. Things typically get better. Call 911 or your local emergency services number if you're in danger. Call or text 988 to reach the Suicide and Crisis Lifeline if you need someone to talk to.

Overview

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Reach out for help if you notice the warning signs of suicide in a friend or loved one.

What is suicide?

Suicide is death caused by self-inflicted injury with the intent to **die**.

It's common among all age groups and affects a wide range of people. You might smile but still think about suicide or be at what you consider the lowest point of your life. Maybe you're somewhere in between, but if the thought of suicide is frequent, you're at risk.

If you're thinking about suicide, if you've attempted suicide or if you've lost someone to suicide — no matter what situation you're in, help is available.

What are the warning signs of suicide?

Suicide doesn't always have clear warning signs. It can happen suddenly, without any indication that something was wrong.

Common warning signs of suicide may include:

- Experiencing suicidal thoughts (**suicidal ideation**)
- Talking about suicide wishes to others
- Hiding suicide wishes from others
- Making preparations like a will or writing a note, giving away valued or meaningful possessions, saying goodbye to loved ones, tidying up a living space, and researching and purchasing weapons or harmful substances

- Reckless, dangerous or risk-taking behavior without considering the consequences (like **self-harm**)
- Withdrawing from loved ones and social situations
- Expressing feelings of being a burden or being trapped in a situation without a clear exit
- Mood changes (anxious, agitated, angry, depressed) or intense emotions
- A sudden sense of calm after a period of mood changes
- Signs that depression is getting worse, including changes to sleeping patterns (sleeping more or less than usual) or not finding joy in things that usually bring on this emotion

If you notice warning signs of suicide, don't hesitate to reach out for help. It may be hard to do, but it can save your life.

What is the suicide hotline?

The U.S. National Suicide Prevention Lifeline, now known as the **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline**, is a resource available to you if you're:

- Thinking about suicide, self-harm or harming others
- Anxious, stressed or having a bad day
- In a crisis
- Facing issues related to who you have sex with or feel attracted to, being transgender or non-binary
- Feeling overwhelmed with things like finances, housing and food access
- Needing someone to talk to or finding it difficult to be alone
- Needing advice if you're concerned about a loved one

In the United States, when you call or text 988, a network of local counselors will help you with any issue you're facing. For crises or situations where your safety is in danger, counselors can send additional help to your location to offer support if you need it.

Someone is available to help you 24/7. You don't have to be in a crisis to contact the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline.

How common is suicide?

Suicide is a leading cause of death in the United States. To break the statistics down by age, suicide is:

- The second leading cause of death between ages 10 to 14 and 25 to 34
- The third leading cause of death between ages 15 to 24
- The fourth leading cause of death between ages 35 and 44

In the U.S. in 2021, 48,183 people died by suicide. This equals one death by suicide every 11 minutes.

Who is at risk of suicide?

Anyone can be at risk of suicide. Suicide affects people globally and doesn't discriminate based on demographics. It doesn't fit a specific mold. It can affect someone who is expressively happy or someone who feels depressed and everyone in between.

You may have a higher risk of suicide if you belong to one of these demographic groups:

- Alaska Native
- Experienced incarceration
- Gay, lesbian or bisexual
- Indigenous
- Isolated (socially or environmentally)
- Non-Hispanic white
- **Male**
- Migrant or refugee
- Older than 65 years of age
- Transgender
- Veteran
- Victim of violence or abuse
- Victim of war or natural disaster

Does talking about suicide increase someone's risk?

No. Talking about suicide doesn't increase someone's risk of taking their own life or putting ideas in their head. Asking someone if they're thinking about suicide can be a lifesaving way to support someone and help them get the care they need.

Why would someone consider suicide?

It's difficult to know exactly why someone would consider suicide unless they told you. Even then, there are often a lot of things that contribute to the decision that someone might not feel comfortable expressing fully. Many times, suicide happens before any information is shared.

Research shows there are common factors that can lead someone to take their own life:

- A previous history of suicide attempts
- An underlying mental health condition
- An underlying medical condition with painful or disabling symptoms or a terminal prognosis
- Financial, legal, housing or employment challenges
- Interpersonal trauma, like physical, emotional or sexual abuse; or neglect, isolation or bullying
- Relationship changes (divorce, a breakup or death of a loved one)

- No access to healthcare or medical services
- Cultural or religious ideals
- Extreme stress

Though this list identifies some of the most common factors, it's not exhaustive.

While suicide isn't genetic, the suicide of a biological loved one does increase your risk of considering suicide yourself.

What psychiatric conditions are associated with suicide?

Some psychiatric conditions may lead you to consider suicide. These could include:

- Anxiety disorders
- Chronic pain
- Depression
- Mood disorders
- Post-traumatic stress disorder
- Schizophrenia
- Substance use disorder or alcohol use disorder
- Traumatic brain injury

If you have an underlying condition that's affecting your will to live, contact a healthcare provider.

Can suicide be prevented?

After a loss to suicide, you may be asking yourself if there's anything you could have done to prevent suicide from happening. While there are many things that we can do as a society to prevent suicide, it isn't entirely preventable and it's ultimately the decision of the person who considers it.

But if someone is thinking about suicide or you notice warning signs, early intervention can reduce someone's risk of suicide. You can take the following steps:

- Learn about the risk factors and warning signs of suicide
- Pay attention to the emotional needs of your friends and loved ones
- Be there to support and listen to those around you
- Start a conversation if you suspect someone is thinking about suicide
- If someone is struggling, encourage them to seek care from a mental health provider
- Contact local emergency services or 988 and remove any dangerous objects from the vicinity if you or someone else is in immediate danger of suicide

People who receive support from loved ones are less likely to act on suicidal impulses. But when discussing suicide, make sure you don't apply judgment. You may think about it negatively, but expressing those feelings to someone who's considering suicide can be harmful.

What is a suicide risk assessment?

A suicide risk assessment is a series of questions that a healthcare provider will ask to identify if you're at risk of taking your own life. There are three parts to a suicide risk assessment:

- **A screening:** This may consist of a few initial questions about suicide.
- **A safety assessment:** If the screening indicates you're at risk, this is the next step. A provider will hold a brief conversation with you to learn more about your risk and if you're in immediate danger. It only takes 10 minutes.
- **Results and treatment:** Your provider will determine the next steps based on the previous screening and assessment results.

Studies found that most people who die by suicide visit a healthcare provider months before their passing. This screening can detect your risk of suicide early so your provider can offer treatment that can save your life. It's available to anyone at any age.

What do I do if I or a loved one is thinking about suicide?

It can be worrisome and scary to experience suicidal ideation or any situation where taking your life might be a possibility. You may also be concerned about the safety of someone you care about if they tell you that they're thinking about suicide or attempted suicide.

The following may help:

- **Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).** Talking to someone can help you, whether you're in a crisis or just having a bad day. Remember, you're not alone. If you or someone you know are in danger or an unsafe situation, call 911 or your local emergency services number immediately.
- **Make a safety plan.** A safety plan is a list of things that can help you or a loved one feel better when they're experiencing a crisis, including suicidal thoughts. This list could include what you can do on your own and with others.
- **Have a conversation with someone you trust.** It could be a friend, a relative, a teacher or a healthcare provider, for example. There are people around you every day who can support you in your time of need.

Within your living space, there are steps you can take to keep yourself or a loved one safe. You'll want to remove or lock away the following items that may cause harm:

- Prescription medications.
- Alcohol or substances.
- Guns or weapons. If guns are present, make sure the bullets are removed and stored separately.

In addition, it helps to stay with someone who is considering suicide. Give them the personal space they need, but don't leave them alone to fend for themselves. It helps to have someone around to talk to and offer support when needed.

Additional Common Questions

What is a suicide attempt?

A suicide attempt is causing harm to yourself with the intent to die, but death isn't the outcome.

A suicide attempt can have a significant impact on your physical and mental health, depending on your means of self-harm. For example, you may have several broken bones after jumping off of a bridge. The amount of pain you're in after a suicide attempt can far outweigh what you may have felt before.

In addition, it's extremely difficult emotionally to come to terms with the fact that you're alive after an attempt to end your life. You may consider your attempt "failed." But suicide isn't the same as hitting the bullseye on a target — it should never be identified as a success or a failure. This word choice could interfere with your ability to heal. You could instead consider yourself a survivor of a suicide attempt and consider your survival a turning point to refocus on your health and safety so that there's no "next time."

It can be difficult to see that there's hope or that things will get better where you're at right now but, for many people, things will get better with time and treatment.

What is assisted suicide?

The American Medical Association describes physician-assisted suicide as the action of a physician providing aid or information to help a patient choose to end their life. In regions where this is legal, a person with a terminal illness may request this from a healthcare provider.

How does suicidal ideation contribute to suicide?

Suicidal ideation (suicidal thoughts or wishes) is thinking about, considering or making a plan to take your own life. It can be a fleeting thought or a continuous stream of harmful ideas. While a thought isn't taking action to end your life, it can lead to it. Help is available for suicidal ideation.

What are suicidal tendencies?

Suicidal tendencies describe an increase in suicidal ideation or self-harm with the intent to die. The term "suicidal tendencies" has fallen out of favor to describe the frequency of suicidal behavior. Instead, the more accurate term is "suicide risk."

A note from Cleveland Clinic

Suicide is scary, heartbreaking and complex. It affects people around the world and is, unfortunately, common. It may not seem like there's any other option, but there is hope and help available.

If someone you know shows warning signs, it's OK to ask if they're thinking about suicide. Listen without judging. Encourage them to talk to a healthcare provider or mental health professional. If you or a loved one are in danger, don't be afraid to reach out.

Experts You Can Trust

✔ Medically Reviewed.

Last updated on 07/22/2024.

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Cleveland Clinic's health articles are based on evidence-backed information and review by medical professionals to ensure accuracy, reliability and up-to-date clinical standards.

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